marksmen found their range and began to bring down large numbers of exposed sepoys. ‘Every bullet fired from the Ghazni Fort struck the English troops like a Divine punishment,’ wrote Mirza ‘Ata. ‘The soldiers remained hungry and the animals stood exhausted from the long march, still carrying their loads till evening, when the camp was finally prepared behind temporary fortifications and entrenchments. A massive cannon called Zuber Zun, the Hard Hitter, was fired from the fort and camels, soldiers and horses were blown into the air like paper-kites.’[85]

That night the British could see signalling with blue lights from the ramparts. The signals were answered by other lights on the mountains to the east. The purpose of these signals did not become apparent until early the following morning when the army was attacked from the rear by a party of 2,000 wild-eyed ghazis [holy warriors] on horseback. Soon after dawn they appeared on the heights behind the camp carrying the green flags of jihad. As bugles sounded the alarm, the foremost of the jihadis managed to ride over the defensive ditches straight into the middle of Shah Shuja’s part of the camp screaming ‘Allah hu-Akbar!’ and fighting with suicidal bravery until they were surrounded.

Only fifty eventually agreed to surrender, and even they, when hauled before Shuja, insulted him as ‘an infidel at heart and a friend of infidels’.[86] As the Shah stood there fuming, one of the ghazis produced a hidden dagger and tried to lunge at him. As soon as the man was overpowered and killed, Shuja’s bodyguards beheaded the entire group of prisoners, much to the horror of Macnaghten. It was reported that Shuja’s executioners were laughing and joking as they set about their work, ‘hacking and maiming the poor wretches indiscriminately with their long swords and knives’, as the prisoners lay pinioned with their hands tied behind their backs. ‘The execution of numerous persons in the vicinity of the British camp threw a very unpleasant light on our proceedings,’ wrote Mohan Lal. ‘Surely no country will admit and approve of the butchery of fifty men in the most cruel and barbarous way for the offence of one individual?’[87]

In the hours that followed, it was Mohan Lal who played the most crucial role in saving the British from the mess they had created for themselves. The previous day, as the invading army had been approaching the fortress, a senior Barakzai prince and rival of Dost Mohammad, Abdul Rashid Khan,